FROM WEB TO COCOON

These economic and geopolitical dynamics could divide the world between two digital empires. During the Cold War, the Iron Curtain was in many places literally made of metal: barbed wire separated one country from another. Now the world is increasingly divided by the Silicon Curtain. The Silicon Curtain is made of code, and it passes through every smartphone, computer and server in the world. The code on your smartphone determines on which side of the Silicon Curtain you live, which algorithms run your life, who controls your attention and where your data flows.

It is becoming difficult to access information across the Silicon Curtain, say between China and the United States, or between Russia and the EU. Moreover, the two sides are increasingly run on different digital networks, using different computer codes. Each sphere obeys different regulations and serves different purposes. In China, the most important aim of new digital technology is to strengthen the state and serve government policies. While private enterprises are given a certain amount of autonomy in developing and deploying AIs, their economic activities are ultimately subservient to the government's political goals. These political goals also justify a relatively high level of surveillance, both online and offline. This means, for example, that though Chinese citizens and authorities do care about people's privacy, China is already far ahead of the United States and other Western countries in developing and deploying social credit systems that encompass the whole of people's lives.[24]

In the United States, the government plays a more limited role. Private enterprises lead the development and deployment of AI, and the ultimate goal of many new AI systems is to enrich the tech giants rather than to strengthen the American state or the current administration. Indeed, in many cases governmental policies are themselves shaped by powerful business interests. But the US system does offer greater protection for citizens' privacy. While American corporations aggressively gather information on people's online activities, they are much more restricted in surveilling people's offline lives. There is also widespread rejection of the ideas behind all-embracing social credit systems.[25]

These political, cultural and regulatory differences mean that each sphere is using different software. In China you cannot use Google or Facebook, and you cannot access Wikipedia. In the United States few people use